

After the Story: No Borrowed Stamp

by Douglxss Burley Johnson

A companion study to *The Fair Weight*

Back to the Catasauqua Fire

Pull your chair in toward the ring. We're going back to the Catasauqua bank under the Race Street Bridge lights, where the Lehigh runs black past the weeds and Whitehall's strip glows faint across the water once the sun drops behind the ridge. A truck shifts gears on Howertown Road. A freight works south toward Bethlehem. Scrap pine catches in a brick ring. Overturned buckets hold two men with unfinished business between them.

Miles Keiper is twenty-four when he tells it, but the summer that matters he was twenty at the counter of Kehler Metals on West Race Street. Chain-link lot. Copper piles. Corrugated office that smelled like hot metal and coffee left on the burner. Vince Rutt ran the floor: twenty-eight, thick from dragging motors, wrenches-and-skull on his forearm. Vince taught Miles the grades, bought him a Bridge Street cheesesteak on the dock, and taught him a rule about fair.

Fair, Vince said, is what you can get away with and still sleep. Wrong is what gets you caught. Ought is whatever keeps the drawer from coming up short on you. He used those words the way a man uses a borrowed ratchet: fair, wrong, ought, should. God, to Vince, was optional. Atoms and luck and the Friday check. Then late one August Thursday, an hour from close, Ortiz rolled in with a truck bed of clean bright copper. Vince slid a thin steel shim under the left pad so the platform would read light by about forty. Split the difference off the cash. Fair, right? Molecules don't care.

Miles did not answer with a speech. He crouched on the grit, pulled the shim free, lifted the yellow certified fifty-pound test weight onto the empty platform, and pressed zero under the plastic cover until the head sat at fifty on the nose. Ortiz got paid the true number. After the truck cleared toward Race Street and the bridge, Vince planted his boots in the dust and pressed the language: There is no wrong without a rulemaker, and there isn't one. Miles stood with the yellow weight warm in his palms and the certified stamp catching late light. You used the words, Miles said. You can't keep the weight and throw out the stamp.

That night they sat by the river fire. Vince said he was not converting. He liked the words. He did not like the Owner. Miles said he was not Vince's Holy Spirit. They did not settle the veil. Vince still works the counter. Miles lifts two fingers when he crosses the bridge. They have not spoken about ought since.

Tonight we're going to sit with that fire and ask what a borrowed rule sounds like when a man's hands are shorting a scale, and what Frank Turek confirms in *Stealing from God* when he names the same theft: morality taken from God while God is waved off as optional.

Questions to Sit With

1. Read Proverbs 11:1 and Leviticus 19:35-36, where a false balance is named an abomination and the Lord calls for just balances and weights. Vince slid a shim under the left pad and still called the short fair. What does a borrowed "fair" do to a scale that needs a certified stamp to mean true?
2. Read Romans 2:14-15, where Gentiles who lack the written law still do by nature what the law requires, and the work of the law shows written on their hearts. Vince denies God and still reaches for ought, wrong, and should when a customer cheats him or a drawer comes short. What does that borrowing already confess about a Lawgiver he will not name?
3. Read James 4:12, where there is one Lawgiver and Judge. Miles zeroed the scale with the yellow weight and left Vince unconverted by the coals. What do your own hands do with the stamp when a friend still wants the words without the Owner?

The Teaching: No Borrowed Stamp

Start where Miles started. Not with a campus debate stage. With a floor scale, a shim, a yellow fifty-pound weight, and a zero button under plastic.

Vince Rutt is not a cartoon villain. He taught a kid the grades. He bought the cheesesteak. He will get mad when a man passes painted pipe as clean copper. Mad needs a real line. That is the whole trouble. Vince wants fair to bite when the bite helps him, and he wants God optional when the Owner would cost him. Frank Turek opens the same theft with a shop-floor plainness that fits a Catasauqua bank better than a lecture hall. He writes, "You can know what a book says while denying there's an author. But there would be no book to know unless there was an author"

(Turek, ch. 4). Then the turn that lands on Vince's mouth: "Likewise, atheists can know objective morality while denying God exists, but there would be no objective morality unless God exists" (Turek, ch. 4). Miles's hands already knew the pinch when the shim came free. Vince could use fair and still sleep. He could not explain why fair meant more than his mood.

Hold that against the scale.

The yellow weight is certified. The stamp on the top face is why fifty means fifty when Kehler's books clear. Miles set that weight on the empty pad and pressed zero until the head agreed. Tools finished the decision. No podium. A counter kid doing what the stamp required while Vince watched from the doorway. Turek names the category Vince keeps confusing. "Sociology is how people behave; morality is how they ought to behave" (Turek, ch. 4). Vince can describe what men get away with on West Race Street. That is sociology. The moment he says Ortiz ought to be shorted, or Miles ought to cut him in, or a customer is wrong to cheat the grade, he has crossed into morality. He has borrowed a rule that belongs to an Owner he will not keep.

Walk the theft the way the lot walked it.

First the words. Vince used fair, wrong, ought, should like a borrowed ratchet. Turek says the quiet part for men who still want the ratchet without the maker: "What I am saying is that atheists can't justify morality. They can act morally and judge some actions as being moral and others immoral" (Turek, ch. 4). Vince acts. Vince judges. Vince cannot ground the judgment. "But they can provide no objective basis for those judgments" (Turek, ch. 4). If there is no Lawgiver, Miles's zero and Vince's shim are only two preferences fighting over forty dollars. Ortiz's missing cash is only atoms moving pocket to pocket. Miles named it. You used the words like they meant more than your mood. Then you said the One who makes those words mean anything is optional.

Second the stamp. "Morality isn't made of molecules" (Turek, ch. 4). That line belongs on the plywood coffee ring beside the yellow weight. Molecules do not write tickets. Molecules do not certify fifty pounds. Molecules do not tell a shift lead he ought not short a pad. Turek presses the same steel: "without God there is no objective, unchanging standard of morality" (Turek, ch. 4). Vince wanted molecules and luck and the Friday check, and he still wanted fair to stay heavy

when a man cheated him. You cannot keep the weight and throw out the stamp. The certified face and the moral claim rise and fall together.

Third the theft named as theft. Turek will not soften it. "In order to hold people morally responsible for their actions, atheists need to steal free will and morality from God" (Turek, ch. 4). Later: "So atheists must steal the grounds for objective moral rights from God while arguing that God doesn't exist" (Turek, ch. 4). That is Vince on the dock. Don't get church on me. There is no scorekeeper. Then, in the next breath, ought and wrong and fair, borrowed and spent. Miles's hands answered with the only tools on the lot that could answer: shim out, weight on, zero pressed, ticket true. The Owner of fair does not change when the shift changes.

Now the discovery piece, because Vince wants to invent fair so he can sleep. Turek closes that door: "People don't determine the right thing to do; they discover it" (Turek, ch. 4). Miles did not invent the stamp on the yellow weight. He discovered what the pad required when a certified standard sat on it. He did not invent ought when the short lit in his head. He ran into a line that was already there. Vince can call it preaching with a test weight. The weight still sat true on the plywood when Kehler came in the next morning.

Scripture keeps the same pressure without a translation quote in our mouths. A false balance is named for what it is, and the Lord calls for honest weights (Proverbs 11:1; Leviticus 19:35-36). Men without the written code still show the law's work on their hearts when they accuse and excuse one another (Romans 2:14-15). There is one Lawgiver and Judge (James 4:12). Miles heard those claims the way a scrap-yard hand hears a scale head settle: accept the stamp or keep borrowing words you have no right to. Turek keeps pointing at the same empty pocket. You can know the book while denying the author. You cannot have the book if no author wrote it.

The veil stayed unanswered that night under the bridge lights. Vince said it plain as copper grades: I'm not converting. Miles left him there. We do not settle Vince's file for him. We settle the stamp. Fair. Wrong. Ought. Those claims need a Judge who does not change when the drawer changes. Latch the plastic cover over the zero button when your hands are done. Leave the yellow weight on its plywood where the morning shift can find it.

Around the Fire: Talk It Over and Take It Home

Talk about the Vince in your crew, or the Vince in your own chest. The man who will borrow fair and wrong and ought when the words protect him, and who will wave God off when the Owner would cost him. Say out loud which words you have been spending like they are free. Miles and Turek are on the same side of that question. Keeping the weight while throwing out the stamp will not make the ticket true when the books clear.

Talk about Miles's tools. He did not win Vince with a speech. He pulled a shim, set a certified weight, and pressed zero. Where do you still try to argue a man into square when his hands have not held the stamp yet? Where do you need to quit being somebody else's Holy Spirit and leave the true ticket in the customer's hand?

Talk about the unanswered veil and the unconverted friend. It is all right that Vince walked back into the office and shut the cash drawer hard. Scripture did not appoint Miles to close Vince's file that night. What Scripture did give us is a Lawgiver, a real line that mad already knows, and a scale that will not read true without its stamp. That is enough wood for one fire.

Try this, this week. Read Proverbs 11:1, Leviticus 19:35-36, Romans 2:14-15, and James 4:12 out loud, slow, with a pencil in your hand. Write a short margin: FAIR NEEDS OWNER. WEIGHT NEEDS STAMP. NO BORROWED RULE. Then write FAIR, WRONG, OUGHT, SHOULD on one side of a scrap and OPTIONAL GOD on the other. Ask which side your mouth has been living on when a drawer runs short or a man cheats you. If you have been keeping the weight and tossing the stamp, set the claim back on the pad in prayer and tell the truth about the zero. Learn James 4:12 by heart as a paraphrase you can say by a river: there is one Lawgiver. Put another piece of scrap pine on. Keep the fire high enough to show you the bridge and the water both. And when a friend stays Vince, leave the true ticket where the fire can see it, click the plastic cover down, and refuse the borrowed stamp.

Works Cited

Turek, Frank. *Stealing from God: Why Atheists Need God to Make Their Case*. Colorado Springs: NavPress, 2014.